STOCKHOLM UNIVERSITY
DEPARTMENT OF ECONOMICS

PLACEMENT OFFICER: Professor David Strömberg
david.stromberg@su.se

VAIBHAV RATHI

vaibhav.rathi@su.se • vrathi0.github.io

BUSINESS ADDRESS

Department of Economics, Stockholm University
Universitetsvägen 10 A, SE-106 91 Stockholm, Sweden

DESIRED RESEARCH AND TEACHING FIELDS

Primary:	Political Economics
Secondary:	Development Economics, Applied Microeconomics, Labor

DISSERTATION TITLE: "Essays in Political Economy and Economic Development"

Expected Date of Completion:	May 2027
Principal Advisor:	Professor David Strömberg
Other References:	Professors Mitch Downey and Andreas Madestam

EDUCATION

	DEGREE	DATE	FIELD
University of California, Berkeley	Visiting PhD Scholar	Fall 2023	
University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy	Master's	2018	Economics Research Methods

RESEARCH PAPERS

Political Influence, Bureaucratic Priorities, and Capital Accumulation in India **(Job Market Paper)**

Does political influence improve bureaucratic performance, or does it merely capture bureaucratic priorities for politically salient tasks? Using party alignment between the local politician and the state govt as a proxy for influence, I show that the influence improves bureaucratic performance along implementation of politically salient welfare programs. Then I turn to a novel empirical setting, regulatory processing of capital investment in India. The data captures regulatory life-cycle of both public and private investment projects. Using two research designs that use independent sources of variation in alignment status, I show that the effect of political influence differs significantly across project type. Both designs generate consistent results, when the influence decreases (increases), bureaucrats respond by giving higher (lower) priority to private investment projects compared to public projects with electoral returns. My results show that political pressure can slow down regulatory approval process for private investment projects by distorting bureaucratic priorities. This also explains why we see varied regulatory burdens of same regulations across countries as well as mixed success from regulatory reforms, as ability of politicians to influence bureaucracy might be the latent factor. Insulating the bureaucracy from political influence can increase the rate of capital accumulation in the economy.

Political Allocation of State Capacity

This paper studies how shifts in local political influence reshape the subnational allocation of the bureaucratic state, even when aggregate bureaucratic strength and formal institutions remain fixed. I develop a framework in which heterogeneity in politicians' influence within state-level posting markets, combined with bureaucrats' career incentives, endogenously reallocates bureaucratic capacity across space. Using India's 2008 electoral delimitation, which quasi-randomly altered districts' exposure to reserved caste politicians, I show that districts newly exposed to reserved constituencies experience a sharp and persistent decline in the flow of incoming bureaucrats, leading to a contraction in local state capacity (size effect) and systematic changes in officer type (composition effect). These effects are driven by

the caste identity of the elected politicians rather than political turnover per se. I formalize two distinct channels that generate these effects: assortative matching and career concerns of bureaucrats and find evidence for both. More broadly, the paper documents an unintended effect of a political reform: policy aimed at increasing political representation also caused a decrease in the local state capacity.

Police Funding Inequality and Police Performance in the US
with Mitch Downey, IIES

Police departments in the USA draw the majority of their funding from revenues generated by local governments. This means that funding for local police can be unequal within a metropolitan area among neighbouring cities. What are the consequences of this arrangement for the allocation of police officers, the quality of police representation in majority-minority communities, and aggregate crime and officer-involved violence? Using a shift-share instrument, we estimate the effects of increasing income inequality in MSAs with high levels of fiscal fragmentation (i.e., instances where the population is divided across many different legally and fiscally independent cities), both relative to increasing inequality when fragmentation is low, and relative to highly fragmented MSAs that do not see increasing inequality.

PUBLICATIONS

Global Biomass Fires and Infant Mortality, *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 120(23): e2218210120, 2023
with Hemant K. Pullabhotla, Mustafa Zahid, Sam Heft-Neal, and Marshall Burke

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Research

Research Assistant, Stanford University 2020
Professor Marshall Burke

Field Research Assistant, J-PAL South Asia 2016
Professor Karthik Muralidharan

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, University of Chicago Spring 2019
Field Experiments for Public Policy, Professor Adam Zelizer
(zelizer@uchicago.edu)

INVITED CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

Development and Political Economics SF Bay Area Ph.D. Student Conference (DevPEC) 2026
Annual ENTER Jamboree 2026
SSE–TSE Cruise Workshop 2026
Nordic PhD Seminar Exchange, Lund University 2026
Annual Swedish Development Economics Conference (ASWEDE) 2026

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

Wallander's & Hedelius Scholarship for economic research, SEK 360,000 (USD 36,000)
Research travel grant, Carl Mannerfelt Foundation, SEK 25,000 (USD 2,500)
CEGA Development Economics Challenge (with Simoni Jain), USD 2,800 2023
Weiss Pilot Grant, BFI, University of Chicago (with Simoni Jain), USD 6,350